SOTONSHIP 2026 · TRACK BRIEF

FinTech

Friday 16 – Sunday 18 October 2026 · Barclays Eagle Labs Southampton
In collaboration with JPMorganChase, Deutsche Bank and TrueMoney

The challenge

Build an AI-powered product that solves a real problem for someone who saves, spends, sends or manages money, and that you could realistically put in front of that person after the weekend. Money now moves in seconds and across borders, and so do the people trying to steal it. Banks, fintechs and wallet providers spend heavily on fraud, compliance and payments operations, while small businesses, migrant workers and vulnerable customers are still poorly served by the financial system. There is no fixed list of projects: you choose the problem, as long as you can show it matters in finance.

SotonShip is about shipping, so judges will look past technical ambition and ask whether your product has a clear user, a working core and a plausible way to be paid for. A simple tool that one fraud team or one group of customers would start using next month will beat an impressive prototype that nobody would adopt.

Before you start building, you should be able to describe your project in one sentence:

> We help **[a specific person]** to **[do or decide something]** in **[part of finance]** using **[AI and the data behind it]**.

For example: *We help remittance users stop scam payments before they leave by spotting the warning signs in the messages that prompted them.*

Who you build for and what fits the track

Choose one main user and design, test and pitch from their point of view. That user could be a customer (a migrant worker sending money home, a student, an older person, someone recovering from a scam), a bank or fintech employee (in fraud, payments operations, compliance and KYC, trade finance or customer services), a small business or sole trader, or a wallet agent or kiosk operator. Working well for one kind of customer, one team or one kind of payment is enough, and it is usually a stronger entry than a tool that tries to cover the whole of finance.

Any real problem in money fits the track, including scams and fraud, money laundering, cross-border payments and remittance, payment data, trade and business verification, small-business cash flow, regulation and compliance, and digital money. The following do not fit, because they either have no clear user or cannot be built fairly in a weekend:

- a general finance chatbot, or a trading bot or price prediction that does not lead to a decision;
- an existing product with an AI feature added on top;

- anything that needs real customer data, live bank credentials or moving real money, unless an organiser has agreed it in advance.

Each team enters one track only. If your idea could also sit in the Southampton City or Responsible AI track, pick the one where your user and your business case are strongest.

What every project must show

A real financial problem. You can say who has the problem, how often it happens and what they do about it today, and you can back that up with evidence such as published data, a regulation or a conversation with someone affected. Putting “finance” on a generic app does not count.

AI that the product depends on. Ask yourself what would happen if you removed the AI. If the product would still do its main job, then AI is not at its core and the idea needs rethinking. Where your AI classifies, predicts or extracts, compare it against a simple baseline so you can show it does better.

A product that works on real data. Someone should be able to complete the main task from start to finish, live, on public or openly licensed data with its source and date visible. Real customer data is off limits, so synthetic data is fine for testing and for anything personal, provided it is labelled as synthetic.

A business case. Explain who would pay for the product or fund it (a bank, a fintech, a wallet provider, businesses or customers), roughly what it would cost to run per user including AI costs, and what it would take to make it work for a second bank or in a second market.

Honesty about limits. The product should show what it does not know, how old its data is, and what happens when data is missing, a source is out of date or an input is outside what it was built for. Show at least one of these failure cases in your demo, because judges trust teams that know where their product breaks.

Directions we want to see

These examples show the kind of project we are hoping for: a specific user, AI doing the hard part, real public data and someone who would pay. You can build one of them, change it, combine them or ignore them completely. Original ideas are judged on exactly the same terms, and following an example earns no extra credit.

A scam check for people sending money home.

Migrant workers sending money abroad are prime targets for scams, including deepfake calls from a “relative in distress”, and UK reimbursement rules do not cover international payments. A tool that reads the message or call behind a transfer, spots the warning signs and warns the sender before the money leaves would protect people the system underserves. A wallet or remittance provider is the customer, because every prevented scam saves a refund, a complaint and a lost user. Compare it with a simple baseline, such as a keyword list. Published scam scripts and public scam reports are a good starting point.

A shell-company check for business onboarding.

Fraudsters open business accounts through shell companies with fake directors and mass-registration addresses. A tool that takes a new business customer's details, pulls their Companies House record and director network, and explains which risk signals it found would save onboarding teams hours on every case. Banks and fintechs that open business accounts are the customer, and because every UK lender runs the same checks, the product has an obvious path to many buyers. Companies House's free API and bulk data are enough to build and test it.

A payment address fixer.

Swift is moving cross-border payments to structured addresses, split into fields such as street, town and country, and will stop accepting addresses written as free text once it agrees the timing with the industry. Many banks still hold their customers' addresses as messy free text, and every one of them will have to fix it. A tool that cleans and structures these addresses, flags the ones it is unsure about and explains why would save payments teams from rejected payments and manual repairs. Transaction banks are the customer, and the same rule applies to every bank on Swift worldwide. Compare your accuracy with simple pattern-matching rules, using open address data such as OpenStreetMap.

A trade document checker.

Before a bank pays out under a letter of credit, staff check by hand that the invoice, bill of lading and other documents match each other and the credit's terms. A tool that reads the documents, extracts the key fields and lists every discrepancy would speed up trade finance teams and catch forged or reused documents. Banks with trade finance businesses are the customer, and could license it per document checked. Public sample trade documents and generated sets with planted errors are enough to build and test it.

Data

There is no compulsory dataset for this track: choose the sources that fit your problem, and check early that they cover the market you chose and that you are allowed to use them. The sources below are good starting points, but you may use any other data you have permission to use, as long as you credit it.

Source	What it offers	Access and limits
Companies House API and bulk data	UK company records, officers, registered addresses, filing history and persons with significant control	Free; the API needs a key. Bulk files are large, so take a slice
UK sanctions list (OFSI / FCDO)	Names, aliases and identifiers of sanctioned people and entities	Free public download; good for name-matching and screening
World Bank Remittance Prices Worldwide	Cost of sending money between country pairs, by provider type	Free download; quarterly, not live prices
Bank of England and ECB exchange rates	Daily reference FX rates	Free; historical reference rates, not live trading rates

Source	What it offers	Access and limits
FCA Register and FCA / Bank of England publications	Authorised firms, warnings about unauthorised firms, policy statements and consultations	Public pages and downloads; check terms before bulk collection
PaySim (Kaggle)	Synthetic mobile-money transactions with fraud labels	Openly available; widely used, so originality must come from your product
IBM AMLworld (Kaggle)	Synthetic transactions with money-laundering patterns labelled	Openly available; large, so sample it
Elliptic dataset (Kaggle)	Bitcoin transaction graph with licit and illicit labels	Openly available; check the licence
Public blockchain explorers (e.g. Etherscan, Basescan)	On-chain token transfers, including stablecoins and deposit tokens	Free tiers need a key and have rate limits
OpenStreetMap	Structured address data	Open (ODbL); credit OpenStreetMap contributors

Some sources need a free account and key. Keep API keys and passwords out of your repository.

Track rules

The event-wide rules apply: teams of four, hacking runs from Friday 20:00 to Sunday 13:00, and you own what you build. In addition, for this track:

- Build your entry during the event and create its repository after hacking opens. Open-source libraries, templates and pre-trained models are fine, but your own earlier projects are not.
- State in your README which parts were AI-generated, what existed before the event and who helped you.
- Show where each number comes from and when it was collected. Never present cached data as live or synthetic data as real.
- Do not use real customer data or connect to a real bank account, card or wallet, and never move real money. Build tools that detect scams and fraud, not tools that create deepfakes, scam scripts or fake documents.
- If your product deals with investment, credit or borrowing, link to official guidance such as the FCA or MoneyHelper rather than giving your own advice.

Deliverables and pitch

Each team submits three things on its team page on the SotonShip Live website, before submissions lock at 13:00 on Sunday:

- **A demo video of 1 to 3 minutes** showing your product in use. Every team must upload its video to YouTube and submit the link.
- **A short summary of about 150 words** that explains who your user is, what problem they have and why it matters, what your solution does and how it could scale.
- **A link to your GitHub repository.**

On Sunday afternoon you then pitch in VC for a Day. The **Judging & how to win** page covers the submission requirements and the suggested pitch structure in full.

Judging and how to win

Every track is judged on the same five criteria: problem and user (20%), AI at the core (20%), working product (25%), business and scale (20%), and responsibility and trust (15%). On Sunday afternoon every team pitches in VC for a Day, where the audience and the judges invest virtual money in the teams they believe in, and the top three teams in each track go on to a final panel that decides the places. The **Judging & how to win** page on the SotonShip Live website explains the whole process, including what to submit, the suggested pitch structure and the extra questions judges ask in this track, so read it before you start building.

For this track in particular, make sure your pitch answers three questions clearly: what evidence shows the problem is real and costly, who would deploy and pay for the product, and what it would take to roll it out to a second bank or market. Your submission locks at 13:00 on Sunday, and your README should list every data source you used with its date and licence.

Key times

When	What happens
Friday 16 October, afternoon and evening	Doors open, followed by talks, the track introductions and a visit and Q&A with the Lord Mayor of Southampton; hacking opens at 20:00
Saturday 17 October	Hacking all day; the venue stays open on Friday and Saturday nights, so you can work and stay overnight
Sunday 18 October, 13:00	Hacking stops and submissions lock, with no extensions
Sunday afternoon	VC for a Day pitches, the final panel and awards

The full timetable is on the **Schedule** page.